> significance of the buffalo; designs and motifs in jewelry, pottery and seals; games of dice and an early form of chess [dice and chess like boards have been found at multiple Harappan sites]; the humble lota which is used to wash up even today; and even the practice of applying sindoor and some measurement systems.[54]

'Personally,' Robinson concludes about the Harappan Civilization, 'I am drawn to what appears to be its success in combining artistic excellence, technological sophistication and economic vigour with social egalitarianism, political freedom and religious moderation over more than half a millennium. If further investigation were to show this attractive picture to be accurate, the Indus civilization would also be a hopeful sign for the future of humankind.'[55] Robinson's view has flourish and humanistic allure, though, if and when the script is deciphered, I suspect he will be proven partially wrong. Until then, what we have is akin to a melodious song in an alien language and whose lyrics remain mysterious to us.

Leaving Dholavira, travelling 100 km southeast, I stop to see the Harappan ruins of Surkotada located by an extinct river that flowed into the Rann. It too has a 'citadel' and a 'lower town'. In its time, Surkotada saw two waves of 'post-Harappans', newcomers who ushered in new styles in materials and objects. It too has a 3.5 m thick fortification wall, nearly as thick as that of Dholavira, and a significant feat of engineering.

On the road to Ahmedabad, I already miss Dholavira and its stark vicinity. Stories swirl in my mind—of villagers, site workers, guides, hotel staff. After this second visit, I'm even more in love with this mysterious site. For opening a vista to my ancestors who still continue to shape my present, it even feels a part of my personal history.

The Harappans invite us to ponder the deepest questions about human nature and culture. Facing ecological challenges as we do today, Dholavirans responded with immense creativity and resolve. Perhaps it is their vulnerability and struggle that make them more endearing to us. Given the looming climate crisis, will our modern age last longer than their mature period of 700 years?[56]